

Linking leader boundary spanning to task performance and its boundary conditions: a conservation of resources perspective

Seckyoung Loretta Kim

*College of Business Administration, Incheon National University,
Incheon, South Korea*

Sunghyuck Mah

College of Business Administration, Seoul National University, Seoul, South Korea

Seoin Yoon

*Department of Management and Entrepreneurship, Arizona State University, Tempe,
Arizona, USA, and*

Seokhwa Yun

College of Business Administration, Seoul National University, Seoul, South Korea

Abstract

Purpose – Drawing on conservation of resources (COR) theory, this research aims to advance the current understanding of leader boundary spanning by examining its effect on task performance, psychological mechanism and boundary conditions.

Design/methodology/approach – The empirical data were gathered by a paper-and-pencil survey from 155 employee-supervisor dyads working in various industries.

Findings – Our results indicated that leader boundary spanning is positively related to task performance, mediated by employees' enhanced self-efficacy. Moreover, the results indicated that the positive effect of leader boundary spanning on task performance via enhanced self-efficacy is strengthened when the level of abusive supervision is low or when the level of an employee's emotional exhaustion is high.

Practical implications – Organizations should find a way to facilitate leaders to engage in boundary spanning behaviors since a leader's boundary spanning behavior enhances task performance through employee's self-efficacy. Additionally, it is crucial to establish policies and provide training sessions to reduce the occurrence of abusive supervision in the workplace.

Originality/value – This study gives insights into the current literature by uncovering whether, how and under what circumstances boundary spanning leaders exert influences on task performance via employees' self-efficacy. Our results showed that the positive effect of leader boundary spanning is likely to be strengthened when boundary spanners do not abuse their employees or when employees are in need of additional resources.

Keywords Leader boundary spanning, Self-efficacy, Abusive supervision, Emotional exhaustion, Conservation of resources (COR) theory

Paper type Research paper

In today's fast-changing and uncertain business environment, the success and survival of organizations can no longer be achieved solely by managing internal dynamics within the organizations (Marrone *et al.*, 2022). The extent to which organizations bridge themselves with key external actors and develop external relationships with them is critical for increasing organizational effectiveness and attaining competitive advantages (Ancona and Caldwell,



This work was supported by the Incheon National University Research Grant in 2023.

Conflicts of interest: We have no conflicts of interest to disclose. Correspondence concerning this article should be addressed to Sunghyuck Mah, College of Business Administration, Seoul National University, Seoul, South Korea.

1992; Liu *et al.*, 2018; Zhang and Li, 2021). In these dynamic contexts, who should take the initiative to bridge diverse and disconnected parties as a boundary spanner? Both researchers and practitioners have increasingly noted that leaders, as representatives of organizations, are responsible for serving as boundary spanners more than ever (Salem *et al.*, 2018). Recognizing the increasing importance of boundary spanning, the current research focuses on *leader boundary spanning*, which refers to a leader's behaviors intended to establish relationships and interactions with external players that can help in meeting overall task goals (Kim *et al.*, 2022), and seeks to examine its positive effect on employee's task performance and the boundary conditions that limit the benefits of leader boundary spanning to advance the literature in the following ways.

First, this research intends to shed new light on the boundary spanning literature by examining leader boundary spanning and its effect on task performance, psychological mechanism, and boundary conditions. Given the high position of leaders who make important decisions and distribute knowledge and information to employees, leaders are better able to understand contextual information in both internal and external areas and communicate with both sides of boundaries (Venkataramani *et al.*, 2014). Despite the significance and effectiveness of leader boundary spanning in the workplace, it is surprising that leader boundary spanning has not received as much scholarly attention as it deserves (e.g. Kim *et al.*, 2022).

Second, given the leaders' critical role as resource providers, conservation of resources (COR) theory (Hobfoll *et al.*, 1990) could be a useful framework to advance our understanding of leader boundary spanning. COR theory states that individuals strive to acquire, conserve, and protect their resources, including object resources, personal resources, and energy resources. In this research, we assume that boundary spanning leaders who acquire critical information or support from external parties are likely to provide job resources to their employees. Then, employees under boundary spanning leaders may feel more capable of achieving challenging task goals. Thus, this study identifies employee's self-efficacy as an internal function of individual employees that can connect leader boundary spanning and task performance. According to COR theory, individuals with sufficient resources are in a better position to obtain new resources, which is referred to as a "*gain spiral*" (Hobfoll *et al.*, 2018). The gain spiral implies that employees who receive valuable resources from their boundary spanning leaders are likely to lead a type of personal resource, namely, an employee's self-efficacy, which may promote high performance.

More importantly, our research underlines the critical role of boundary factors, which limit the positive effect of leader boundary spanning behavior on task performance through self-efficacy. Given the importance of boundary spanning and task performance in the workplace, it is necessary to identify the barriers that may inhibit employees from fully absorbing benefits from leader boundary spanning. Specifically, we select a leader's abusive supervision as a situational factor and an employee's emotional exhaustion as an individual factor. The reason we chose these boundary factors is that they may best represent the depleted level of situational and individual resources. It is worthwhile examining these barriers simultaneously to advance our understanding of the boundary spanning process within a COR framework.

Theoretical background and hypotheses

Leader boundary spanning and task performance

Since the concept of boundary spanning was introduced in team research, a substantial body of work has focused exclusively on team boundary spanning and its effects on team outcomes (e.g. Ancona and Caldwell, 1990, 1992; Marrone *et al.*, 2007). However, because the foundation of team-level boundary spanning behavior is rooted in individual-level boundary spanning behavior (Marrone, 2010), it is theoretically and practically important to examine individual-level boundary spanning behavior and its potential outcomes. Leader boundary spanning encompasses a broad array of externally oriented activities by a leader, including persuading outsiders to provide support, acquiring critical information or resources from external

stakeholders, and negotiating project content with individuals both outside the organization and in different units within organizations (e.g. Kim *et al.*, 2022).

According to COR theory (Hobfoll *et al.*, 1990), a resource is defined as anything perceived by individuals to help them attain their goals. Boundary spanning leaders, as primary resource providers, offer such resources that are particularly useful for enhancing employee task performance because these resources can be used to address problems that cannot be solved with the resources currently available within the unit's boundaries. By cultivating close relationships with senior managers in different organizational units and seeking their support, boundary spanning leaders can provide employees with the essential knowledge and information needed to resolve problems and manage task difficulties (Liu *et al.*, 2018). Leaders can also acquire valuable feedback, guidance, or advice from senior executives, which can help employees manage task strategies more efficiently (Kim *et al.*, 2022). Additionally, leaders who maintain close ties with external parties outside organizations can help employees keep abreast of up-to-date opportunities and threats in the business market, allowing them to adjust their work accordingly (Gurău *et al.*, 2020). Since employees have limited access to these critical external actors compared to leaders, resources obtained through leader boundary spanning are especially important for task performance (Marrone *et al.*, 2022).

H1. Leader boundary spanning is positively related to task performance.

Mediating effect of an employee's self-efficacy

An employee's self-efficacy, which refers to "an individual's belief in one's capability to organize and execute the courses of action required to produce given attainments" (Bandura, 1997, p. 3), is a major driving force in determining one's performance. Employees with high self-efficacy set higher goals, take initiative, and exert more effort to handle challenges in their work, thereby performing better (Downes *et al.*, 2021). Researchers have thus sought to identify constructive leader behaviors that can facilitate an employee's self-efficacy, such as transformational leadership and ethical leadership (Djourouva *et al.*, 2020). In this research, we apply COR theory to demonstrate how a leader's externally oriented behavior, namely, leader boundary spanning, can improve task performance by strengthening an employee's self-efficacy.

Critical resources provided by boundary spanning leaders are likely to help employees develop high self-efficacy. Task-related support from external parties, both inside and outside organizational boundaries, can be "the major vehicle by which individuals' resources are widened outside the limited domain of resources that are contained in the self" (Hobfoll *et al.*, 1990, p. 467). In a favorable context where leaders exert influence across boundaries to meet task objectives, employees who acquire important external resources are likely to believe that they can accomplish performance goals, thereby achieving a high level of self-efficacy.

An employee's increased efficacy beliefs, resulting from the additional resources provided by a leader's boundary spanning behavior, are likely to lead to a high level of task performance. Believing that they can utilize valuable feedback on progress from key external actors and richer discussions with them, employees under boundary spanning leaders are likely to commit to task goals, initiate goal-directed actions, and invest more effort and time in their tasks (Bandura, 1997). Since employees with high self-efficacy tend to act consistently with their positive self-evaluation by engaging in self-regulation, they willingly set difficult goals and put in more effort to achieve higher performance (e.g. Gielnik *et al.*, 2020). The gain spiral of COR theory (Hobfoll *et al.*, 2018) posits that employees who acquire a wealth of resources, such as information and knowledge from their boundary spanning leaders, are likely to develop personal resources, such as self-efficacy, which may lead to high performance.

H2. An employee's self-efficacy mediates the positive relationship between leader boundary spanning and task performance.

Moderated mediation effect of abusive supervision

Abusive supervision refers to “subordinates’ perceptions of the extent to which their supervisors engage in a sustained display of hostile, verbal, and non-verbal behaviors excluding physical contact” (Tepper, 2000, p. 178). Abusive supervision has been found to cause victims’ depression, anxiety, and psychological detachment, as well as harm their self-esteem, intrinsic motivation, and organizational commitment (Fischer *et al.*, 2021). Since abusive supervision exemplifies a lack of critical contextual resources (i.e. social support) identified by COR theory (Hobfoll *et al.*, 2018) and substantially influences victims’ work attitudes and behaviors, it could act as a strong situational context that may moderate the relationship between leadership and employee outcomes (e.g. Kim and Yun, 2015).

Scholars have suggested that the effectiveness of boundary spanning behaviors can vary depending on the internal activities of boundary spanners, emphasizing the synergy or alignment between internal and external behaviors (Venkataramani *et al.*, 2014). Given the limitations of one’s resources, it is challenging for leaders to maintain a balance between internal and external role behaviors (Hobfoll *et al.*, 2018). As leaders often span boundaries with the purpose of achieving better performance (Marrone *et al.*, 2022), this underlying motive may cause them to forcefully push their subordinates in response to the increased input. This could be an example of leaders engaging in both desirable behaviors (i.e. boundary spanning) and undesirable behaviors (i.e. abusive supervision) (e.g. Lian *et al.*, 2012). Based on COR theory, this study suggests how abusive supervision may impede the positive effect of leader boundary spanning on self-efficacy.

According to COR theory (Hobfoll *et al.*, 1990), individuals experience psychological stress when their resources are lost or threatened with loss. Since inconsistent or contradictory leader behaviors tend to exacerbate the situation (Vullingsh *et al.*, 2020), abusive leaders who perform boundary spanning behaviors may have detrimental effects on employees by increasing conflicts and dissonance (e.g. Lian *et al.*, 2012). Duffy *et al.* (2002) suggested that when supervisors support but also undermine employees, it thwarts their self-efficacy, as such inconsistent behaviors deplete more of the employees’ coping resources. Additionally, Lian *et al.* (2012) noted that when supervisors provide valuable job resources while simultaneously perpetrating abusive supervision, employees perceive a greater threat to their need for competence and deplete their emotional and cognitive resources for self-regulation. In this respect, employees who use up their resources in dealing with the dissonance caused by abusive leaders performing boundary spanning are likely to feel resource depletion, which may lead to low levels of self-efficacy. In contrast, the gain spiral of COR theory (Hobfoll *et al.*, 2018) posits that when boundary spanning leaders do not abuse their employees, employees may possess sufficient resources to increase personal resources such as self-efficacy.

H3a. Abusive supervision moderates the effect of leader boundary spanning on an employee’s self-efficacy, such that the effect is strengthened when abusive supervision is low rather than high.

We suggest a moderated mediation model and propose that leader boundary spanning relates positively and indirectly to employees’ task performance through self-efficacy; this indirect linkage depends on the level of abusive supervision. Since inconsistent leader behaviors can induce conflicts and dissonance (Vullingsh *et al.*, 2020), abused employees working under boundary spanning leaders may not be able to achieve high task performance through self-efficacy. In contrast, when boundary spanning leaders successfully manage internal relationships with their subordinates by refraining from abusive supervision, employees are able to develop their personal resources such as self-efficacy, leading to a high level of task performance.

H3b. Abusive supervision moderates the indirect effect of leader boundary spanning on task performance via an employee’s self-efficacy, such that the indirect effect is strengthened when abusive supervision is low rather than high.

Moderated mediation effect of emotional exhaustion

Emotional exhaustion refers to feelings of being emotionally overburdened and depleted of one's emotional resources by one's work (Maslach *et al.*, 2001). As one of three dimensions of burnout, emotional exhaustion has been recognized as a primary component of job burnout due to its consistent relationships with important organizational outcomes, such as job performance, commitment, job satisfaction, and turnover intention (Lavelle *et al.*, 2021). Emotional exhaustion, which represents the depletion of an individual's emotional resources (Maslach and Jackson, 1981), is meaningful moderator that demonstrates when the positive effect of leader boundary spanning is altered.

According to COR theory, employees who feel emotionally and physically depleted do not have sufficient resources and thus may feel stress as a result. Dust *et al.* (2018) showed that the positive effect of ethical leadership on psychological empowerment is hampered when employees are emotionally exhausted. In a similar vein, the positive linkage between leader boundary spanning behavior and self-efficacy would be weakened for exhausted employees. Since emotionally exhausted employees are likely to show a low level of responsiveness and availability (Lam *et al.*, 2010), they tend to be passive in utilizing the resources provided by their boundary spanning leaders. In contrast, when employees are not significantly emotionally exhausted, they tend to be more responsive to external input (Lam *et al.*, 2010), which could help build a high level of self-efficacy.

H4a. An employee's emotional exhaustion moderates the effect of leader boundary spanning on an employee's self-efficacy, such that the effect is strengthened when an employee's emotional exhaustion is low rather than high.

Employees' emotional exhaustion is also expected to moderate the overall indirect effect of leader boundary spanning on task performance through self-efficacy. Specifically, emotionally exhausted employees' low responsiveness and receptivity to incoming resources (Hobfoll *et al.*, 2018) are likely to weaken the relationship between leader boundary spanning and self-efficacy at the first stage of the mediation process, leading to a weaker overall mediation effect. Conversely, when emotional exhaustion is low, employees are more likely to actively learn and absorb the resources provided by leader boundary spanning, resulting in a more pronounced improvement in task performance through self-efficacy.

H4b. An employee's emotional exhaustion moderates the indirect effect of leader boundary spanning on task performance via an employee's self-efficacy, such that the indirect effect is strengthened when an employee's emotional exhaustion is low rather than high.

Method

Sample and procedure

We collected survey data in South Korea. To secure field data, one author reached out to both leaders and employees through professional networks available to us. We explained the nature of the study, which required leaders and employees to participate together with their respective subordinates or supervisors, and provided them with a survey packet containing detailed information. Each leader or employee directly contacted by the researcher, along with the employee or supervisor they invited, received an individually assigned envelope. The envelope contained an explanation of the voluntary nature of the study as well as the procedures involved. The subsequent steps were followed only if both the leader and the employee agreed to participate. Consequently, some of the 200 packets distributed were excluded, resulting in 163 dyads completing the study. The leader and subordinate were each instructed to complete their respective surveys, enclose them in their assigned envelope, and seal them themselves to ensure the confidentiality of their responses. These sealed envelopes were then either handed directly to the researcher or sent via mail. The returned survey packets were matched between dyads

using pre-assigned code numbers. Our analytical tool, *Mplus*, does not account for missing values in predictors (Muthén and Muthén, 2017). Therefore, responses with missing independent variable values were excluded, resulting in a final sample of 155 dyads for analysis [1]. The average age of the employees in this final sample was 31.21 years ($SD = 6.17$), with 41.9% identifying as female. 73.6% held a bachelor's degree. On average, they had worked with their leader for 1.72 years, with durations ranging from 0.83 to 13 years. The average organizational tenure was 3.44 years, with a range from 0.17 to 30 years.

Measures

Following the guidelines of Brislin (1980), we translated all the measures used in this study into Korean. The employees were asked to evaluate their immediate supervisors' boundary spanning behavior and abusive supervision, as well as their own self-efficacy and emotional exhaustion. All the items were rated on a 7-point Likert scale (1 = *strongly disagree* and 7 = *strongly agree*).

Leader boundary spanning. Leader boundary spanning was evaluated using the 6-item measure developed by Marrone et al. (2007). The sample item is "My supervisor acquires resources and access (e.g. access to information) for the team" ($\alpha = 0.94$).

Self-efficacy. We used Chen et al.'s (2001) 8-item measure to assess an employee's self-efficacy. "I will be able to successfully overcome many challenges" represents a sample item ($\alpha = 0.95$).

Abusive supervision. We adopted the 5-item scale used by Peng et al. (2014), which is a shortened version of Tepper's (2000) scale, to measure abusive supervision. This scale includes three items measuring active types of aggression and two items measuring passive types of aggression. An example item is, "My supervisor puts me down in front of others" ($\alpha = 0.94$).

Emotional exhaustion. We used Maslach and Jackson's (1981) 9-item measure to assess an employee's emotional exhaustion. "I feel emotionally drained from my work" represents a sample item ($\alpha = 0.93$).

Task performance. Direct supervisors independently evaluated their employees' task performance using the 4-item scale (Peng et al., 2014), derived from Williams and Anderson's (1991) measure based on the highest factor loadings. A sample item includes "This employee adequately completes assigned duties" ($\alpha = 0.95$).

Control variables. We controlled gender, age, education level, and dyadic tenure with the leader to exclude their potential effects. Age and dyadic tenure were measured in years, whereas gender was measured as a dichotomous variable (1 = *male*, 2 = *female*). Education level was measured on a 4-point Likert scale, ranging from "high school" to "master's degree or higher."

Results

Table 1 presents the descriptive statistics for the variables included in the model. To affirm its discriminant validity, we first conducted a confirmatory factor analysis. The fit index of our research model with five factors was satisfactory with $\chi^2 (454) = 747.14$, $p < 0.001$, $CFI = 0.94$, $TLI = 0.93$, $RMSEA = 0.07$. This was a superior fit to a four-factor model where two leader-related measures were set on a single factor, $\Delta \chi^2 (4) = 560.67$, $p < 0.001$, or a four-factor model where two self-related measures were combined, $\Delta \chi^2 (4) = 735.24$, $p < 0.001$, or a two-factor model where all employee-rated measures were combined, $\Delta \chi^2 (9) = 2113.37$, $p < 0.001$. Following Xu et al. (2024), we conducted a post-hoc power analysis for our moderated mediation model. The calculated power ($N = 155$) for the moderated mediation effects of abusive supervision and emotional exhaustion was 0.752 and 0.829, respectively.

To estimate the hypothesized effects simultaneously, we utilized a path analysis with *Mplus* 8.7 (Muthén and Muthén, 2017). We also mean-centered all predicting variables to better interpret the results. Table 2 showed that leader boundary spanning was significantly and

Table 1. Descriptive statistics and correlations among variables

	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1. Age	31.21	6.17								
2. Gender	1.42	0.50	−0.10							
3. Education	2.97	0.66	0.25**	−0.03						
4. Dyadic tenure with leader	1.72	2.08	0.42**	−0.07	−0.03					
5. Leader boundary spanning	5.32	1.08	−0.03	−0.14	0.07	0.13				
6. Self-efficacy	5.40	0.92	0.18*	−0.11	0.08	0.08	0.37**			
7. Abusive supervision	1.99	1.15	0.06	0.13	−0.06	0.02	−0.51**	−0.34**		
8. Emotional exhaustion	3.43	1.21	−0.13	0.15	0.03	−0.00	−0.11	−0.39**	0.25**	
9. Task performance ^a	5.85	0.95	−0.13	−0.12	0.06	0.02	0.44**	0.34**	−0.44**	−0.12

Note(s): *N* = 155. ^aSupervisor-rated. Gender (1 = male, 2 = female). **p* < 0.05. ***p* < 0.01
Source(s): Created by author

Table 2. Unstandardized results of moderated mediation path model

Variables	Self-efficacy			Task performance		
	Estimate	SE	<i>p</i>	Estimate	SE	<i>p</i>
<i>Control variable</i>						
Age	0.02	0.01	0.11	−0.03*	0.01	0.01
Gender	−0.02	0.12	0.90	−0.12	0.13	0.36
Education	0.13	0.10	0.20	0.11	0.10	0.30
Dyadic tenure with leader	0.002	0.03	0.94	0.02	0.04	0.52
<i>Main effect</i>						
Leader boundary spanning	0.23***	0.07	<0.001	0.28**	0.07	<0.001
Abusive supervision	−0.18**	0.07	0.007			
Emotional exhaustion	−0.22***	0.05	<0.001			
<i>Mediator</i>						
Self-efficacy				0.25**	0.08	0.002
<i>Interactions</i>						
Leader boundary spanning × Abusive supervision	−0.11**	0.04	0.006			
Leader boundary spanning × Emotional exhaustion	0.09*	0.04	0.03			
Residual variances	0.60***	0.07	<0.001	0.73***	0.06	<0.001
<i>R</i> ²		0.40			0.28	

Note(s): *N* = 155. All variables were centered on their means. Figures indicate unstandardized coefficients.
p* < 0.05. *p* < 0.01
Source(s): Created by author

positively related to task performance ($b = 0.28, p < 0.001$), thereby supporting [Hypothesis 1](#). Leader boundary spanning had a significant effect on self-efficacy ($b = 0.23, p < 0.001$), and the effect of self-efficacy on task performance was significant ($b = 0.25, p = 0.002$), suggesting an indirect effect. We conducted a bias-corrected bootstrapping analysis to estimate this indirect effect more accurately. As indicated in [Table 3](#), the indirect effect of leader

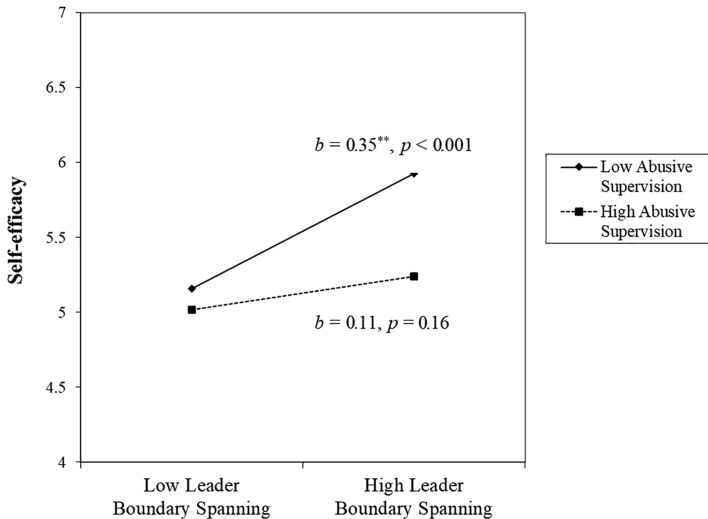
Table 3. Results of moderated mediation analysis

Indirect and moderated indirect effects	Dependent variable: task performance			
	Estimate	SE	LL 95% CI	UL 95% CI
<i>Indirect effect of leader boundary spanning on performance via self-efficacy</i>				
	0.06*	0.03	0.01	0.12
<i>Conditional indirect effect of leader boundary spanning on performance at</i>				
High abusive supervision (+1SD)	0.03	0.03	−0.01	0.10
Low abusive supervision (−1SD)	0.09*	0.04	0.03	0.18
Difference	−0.06*	0.04	−0.17	−0.01
<i>Conditional indirect effect of leader boundary spanning on performance at</i>				
High emotional exhaustion (+1SD)	0.08*	0.04	0.03	0.18
Low emotional exhaustion (−1SD)	0.03	0.03	−0.01	0.10
Difference	0.06*	0.03	0.01	0.15
Note(s): Bias-corrected bootstrap sample size = 5,000. CI = confidence interval. LL = lower limit. UL = upper limit. *95% of CIs did not include zero				
Source(s): Created by author				

boundary spanning on task performance via self-efficacy was positive (0.06), and the 95% CIs did not contain zero [0.01, 0.12]. This supported [Hypothesis 2](#).

[Hypothesis 3a](#) proposed that the relationship between leader boundary spanning and self-efficacy would be strengthened when abusive supervision is low rather than high. The interaction term between leader boundary spanning and abusive supervision was significant ($b = -0.11$, $p = 0.006$, in [Table 2](#)), and the pattern depicted in [Figure 1](#) aligned with our expectation, thereby supporting [Hypothesis 3a](#).

[Hypothesis 3b](#) predicted that the indirect effect of leader boundary spanning on task performance via self-efficacy would also be strengthened when abusive supervision is low. As shown in [Table 3](#), the indirect effect was significant only at low levels of abusive supervision ($b = 0.09$, $SE = 0.04$,



Note(s): Coefficients and p -values are the results of simple slope tests. ** $p < 0.01$

Source(s): Created by author

Figure 1. Moderation effect of abusive supervision

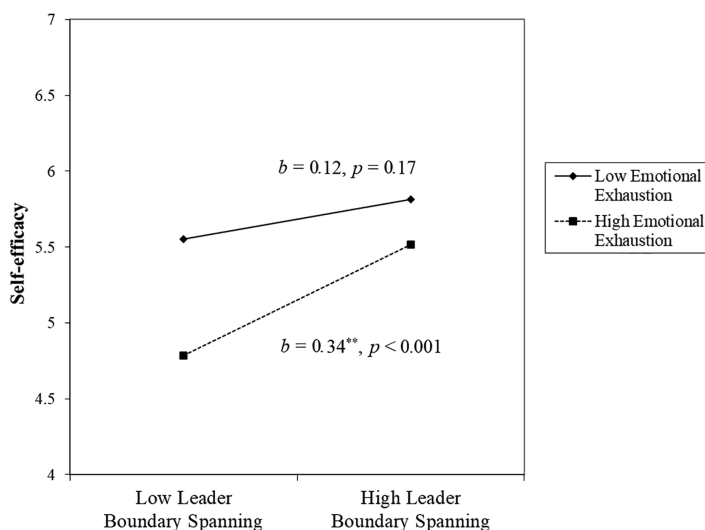
95% CIs = [0.03, 0.18]) but not at high levels ($b = 0.03$, $SE = 0.03$, 95% CIs = [-0.01, 0.10]). The difference between these conditions was also significant ($difference = -0.06$, $SE = 0.04$, 95% CIs = [-0.17, -0.01]). These findings supported [Hypothesis 3b](#).

[Hypothesis 4a](#) proposed that the relationship between leader boundary spanning and self-efficacy would be strengthened when emotional exhaustion is low rather than high. The interaction term between leader boundary spanning and emotional exhaustion was significant ($b = 0.09$, $p = 0.03$, in [Table 2](#)), however, the pattern depicted in [Figure 2](#) was contrary to our expectation, showing a stronger effect when emotional exhaustion was *high* rather than low. Consequently, [Hypothesis 4a](#) was not supported.

[Hypothesis 4b](#) predicted that the indirect effect of leader boundary spanning on task performance via self-efficacy would be strengthened when emotional exhaustion is low rather than high. Contrary to this expectation, the conditional indirect effect of leader boundary spanning was significant at *high* levels of emotional exhaustion ($b = 0.08$, $SE = 0.04$, 95% CIs = [0.03, 0.18]) but not at *low* levels ($b = 0.03$, $SE = 0.03$, 95% CIs = [-0.01, 0.10]). Although the difference between these conditions was significant ($difference = 0.06$, $SE = 0.03$, 95% CIs = [0.01, 0.15]), [Hypothesis 4b](#) was not supported.

Discussion

The present study investigated the effect of leader boundary spanning on task performance, its psychological mechanism, and contextual moderators. Consistent with our prediction, boundary spanning leaders enhanced employees' task performance by getting them access to valued resources from external environments, and this relationship was mediated by employees' heightened self-efficacy. Moreover, the result of this study revealed that the positive effect of leader boundary spanning on task performance via self-efficacy was significant only when the level of abusive supervision was low. In contrast to our prediction, the positive effect of leader boundary spanning on task performance via self-efficacy was stronger when an employee's emotional exhaustion was high rather than when it was low. There might be a plausible reason for this finding.



Note(s): Coefficients and p -values are the results of simple slope tests. $**p < 0.01$

Source(s): Created by author

Figure 2. Moderation effect of emotional exhaustion

Our result may suggest that the benefits of boundary spanning are more pronounced for employees who are in greater need of valued resources—namely, emotionally exhausted employees. A number of studies have documented that the beneficial effects of leadership may be more substantial for some followers who lack resources such as psychological states or individual differences (e.g. [Taylor and Pattie, 2014](#)). For example, prior research showed that low conscientiousness and low core self-evaluation ([Taylor and Pattie, 2014](#)) or low self-esteem ([Avey et al., 2011](#)) could strengthen the positive impacts of leadership behaviors on outcomes. Recent research showed how the positive relationship between boundary spanning and team vigor is strengthened in the context of high team workload because they need sufficient resources to meet the challenges ([Leicht-Deobald et al., 2022](#)). Consistent with the prior studies, our result demonstrated that the positive impact of a leader's boundary spanning behavior on task performance via an employee's self-efficacy would be more beneficial for those emotionally exhausted employees.

Theoretical implications

Our research provides significant theoretical insights into the extant literature. First, this research applies COR theory as a theoretical framework to examine whether, how, and under what circumstances boundary spanning leaders exert influences on task performance via employees' self-efficacy. Taking a COR theory perspective, our findings suggest that leader boundary spanning provides valuable resources to increase task performance through self-efficacy. Furthermore, our results demonstrated how abusive supervision could deplete the resources and limit the positive effect of leader boundary spanning on task performance via self-efficacy. In future research, it will be fruitful to explore other potential psychological mechanisms through which boundary spanning influences employee work behaviors, such as increased psychological safety, to gain a more comprehensive understanding of its impact.

Second, this research demonstrated the importance of considering situational and individual moderators in order to deepen our understanding of the boundary spanning process.

As [Marrone \(2010\)](#) highlighted the importance of examining “contingencies to the boundary spanning – performance relationship” (p. 933), it is necessary to dedicate more attention to the conditions of boundary spanning. To address this issue, this research investigates abusive supervision and emotional exhaustion as barriers that may limit the benefits of leader boundary spanning. Recent research has explored need for status and creative self-efficacy as individual moderators and investigated a three-way effect in the relationship between leader boundary spanning behavior and employee creative behavior ([Kim et al., 2022](#)). Applying COR theory, our result exhibited how employees who experience boundary spanning leaders who are not abusive are likely to possess sufficient resources, which may lead to a high level of task performance via improved self-efficacy. In addition, based on COR theory, we hypothesized that the positive effects of leader boundary spanning behavior on self-efficacy and task performance via self-efficacy would be stronger when emotional exhaustion is low.

Contrary to our prediction, our result demonstrated that a leader's boundary spanning behavior can be more beneficial in enhancing an employee's self-efficacy and task performance via an employee's self-efficacy for those who are emotionally exhausted or are in need of resources. Specifically, our plot exhibited that the positive effect of leader boundary spanning behavior on employee's self-efficacy is strengthened when an employee's emotional exhaustion is high, which was not consistent with our hypothesis but may align with boundary spanning literature. [Marrone \(2010, p. 930\)](#) noted that “adverse conditions perhaps necessitate a greater need for boundary spanning and increase the likelihood and salience of benefits” to recipients of additional job resources, thereby fostering the internal functioning of the recipients. Since employees with a feeling of emotional exhaustion have scant self-resources necessary to initiate task-related actions at work ([Halbesleben and Bowler, 2007](#)), those employees may depend more on their boundary spanning leaders to build up positive

beliefs in their ability to succeed and perform better. In future research, it is worthwhile to examine under what conditions leaders' boundary spanning behavior could be more critical and beneficial, particularly in the context of a lack of resources.

Lastly, the present study contributes to the leadership literature by delving into a leader's externally focused behavior, namely, boundary spanning behavior and its positive impacts. In addition to examine a direct effect of a leader's external behavior, this study exhibited how the interplay of a leader's internal and external behaviors may affect task performance through an employee's self-efficacy. Our result exhibited that leader boundary spanning could be less impactful if leader's internal behavior is destructive. Specifically, we revealed how a leader's destructive internal behavior such as abusive supervision could be a barrier that reduces the positive effect of leader's boundary spanning behavior on task performance via self-efficacy because employees may feel conflicts and dissonance for the leader's inconsistent behavior. Exploring the complex dynamics of leader boundary spanning can be a promising and primary research area that deserves future research attention.

Practical implications

This study also provides practical implications. First, our results indicate that a leader's boundary spanning behavior enhances task performance via increased self-efficacy. Therefore, organizations should find ways to encourage leaders to engage more actively in such activities. However, leaders inevitably face challenges allocating their limited resources between internal and external activities (Marrone, 2010). Consequently, if leaders do not perceive boundary spanning as part of their responsibilities, they may focus solely on internal care and not give sufficient attention to these critical behaviors (Marrone *et al.*, 2007). Therefore, organizations should incorporate boundary spanning behaviors into leader selection, training, development, and appraisal systems to promote adoption.

Second, organizations should establish policies and provide training sessions to reduce the occurrence of inconsistent and destructive leader behaviors in the workplace. Since boundary spanning activities are only truly effective when leaders do not engage in abusive behaviors towards their employees, leaders should recognize the importance of positive internal behaviors to enhance the beneficial effects of boundary spanning on individual outcomes.

Third, our results demonstrate that boundary spanning leaders can be instrumental in supporting emotionally exhausted employees to achieve effective organizational functioning. It would be beneficial for organizations to focus on emotionally exhausted employees by connecting them to essential job resources in external areas. Highly depleted employees require additional resources to overcome their exhaustion, and boundary spanning leaders are well-positioned to facilitate this support.

Limitations and future research

This research has several limitations. First, our convenience sampling approach is susceptible to bias, which may limit the generalizability of our findings (Landers and Behrend, 2015). Future research should validate these results with probability sampling and diverse subjects. Second, the inference of the causal relationship could be restricted due to our cross-sectional research design. There is a possibility of reverse causality, where variables could predict each other in a recursive manner. Therefore, future research using a longitudinal design could help verify the relationships among focal variables more precisely. Third, measuring leader boundary spanning solely through employee reports may not have fully captured the breadth of the leader's boundary spanning activities. Not all activities at the leader level are readily observed by employees. Future research could benefit from measuring leader boundary spanning behavior using multiple sources and comparing the differences between employees' perceptions and leaders' self-evaluations. Finally, our research may have been limited by not including all potential variables that could affect the hypothesized relationships. For example, it might be worthwhile to include employees' boundary spanning behavior and personalities

(e.g. conscientiousness) as control variables since these variables may affect our research model. Additionally, from the perspective of role model theory, future research could examine whether leader boundary spanning influences subordinates to engage in boundary spanning themselves.

Despite these limitations, this study offers valuable insights into the literature by uncovering whether, how, and under what circumstances boundary spanning leaders influence task performance via employees' self-efficacy. The findings suggest that the positive effect of leader boundary spanning is likely to be strengthened either when boundary spanners do not abuse their employees or when employees are in need of additional resources. We hope this study motivates future scholars to further explore how boundary spanning leaders affect employees.

Notes

1. When we conducted the analysis using the original data ($N = 163$), excluding control variables with missing data, the results were not significantly different.

References

- Ancona, D.G. and Caldwell, D.F. (1990), "Beyond boundary spanning: managing external dependence in product development teams", *The Journal of High Technology Management Research*, Vol. 1 No. 2, pp. 119-135, doi: [10.1016/1047-8310\(90\)90001-k](https://doi.org/10.1016/1047-8310(90)90001-k).
- Ancona, D.G. and Caldwell, D.F. (1992), "Bridging the boundary: external activity and performance in organizational teams", *Administrative Science Quarterly*, Vol. 37 No. 4, pp. 634-665, doi: [10.2307/2393475](https://doi.org/10.2307/2393475).
- Avey, J.B., Palanski, M.E. and Walumbwa, F.O. (2011), "When leadership goes unnoticed: the moderating role of follower self-esteem on the relationship between ethical leadership and follower behavior", *Journal of Business Ethics*, Vol. 98 No. 4, pp. 573-582, doi: [10.1007/s10551-010-0610-2](https://doi.org/10.1007/s10551-010-0610-2).
- Bandura, A. (1997), *Self-Efficacy: The Exercise of Control*, Freeman, New York, NY.
- Brislin, R.W. (1980), "Translation and content analysis of oral and written materials", in Triandis, H.C. and Berry, J.W. (Eds), *Handbook of Cross-Cultural Psychology*, Allyn & Bacon, Boston, pp. 389-444.
- Chen, G., Gully, S.M. and Eden, D. (2001), "Validation of a new general self-efficacy scale", *Organizational Research Methods*, Vol. 4 No. 1, pp. 62-83, doi: [10.1177/109442810141004](https://doi.org/10.1177/109442810141004).
- Djourouva, N.P., Rodríguez Molina, I., Tordera Santamatilde, N. and Abate, G. (2020), "Self-efficacy and resilience: mediating mechanisms in the relationship between the transformational leadership dimensions and well-being", *Journal of Leadership and Organizational Studies*, Vol. 27 No. 3, pp. 256-270, doi: [10.1177/1548051819849002](https://doi.org/10.1177/1548051819849002).
- Downes, P.E., Crawford, E.R., Seibert, S.E., Stoverink, A.C. and Campbell, E.M. (2021), "Referents or role models? The self-efficacy and job performance effects of perceiving higher performing peers", *Journal of Applied Psychology*, Vol. 106 No. 3, pp. 422-438, doi: [10.1037/apl0000519](https://doi.org/10.1037/apl0000519).
- Duffy, M.K., Ganster, D.C. and Pagon, M. (2002), "Social undermining in the workplace", *Academy of Management Journal*, Vol. 45 No. 2, pp. 331-351, doi: [10.5465/3069350](https://doi.org/10.5465/3069350).
- Dust, S.B., Resick, C.J., Margolis, J.A., Mawritz, M.B. and Greenbaum, R.L. (2018), "Ethical leadership and employee success: examining the roles of psychological empowerment and emotional exhaustion", *The Leadership Quarterly*, Vol. 29 No. 5, pp. 570-583, doi: [10.1016/j.leaqua.2018.02.002](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.leaqua.2018.02.002).
- Fischer, T., Tian, A.W., Lee, A. and Hughes, D.J. (2021), "Abusive supervision: a systematic review and fundamental rethink", *The Leadership Quarterly*, Vol. 32 No. 6, 101540, doi: [10.1016/j.leaqua.2021.101540](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.leaqua.2021.101540).
- Gielnik, M.M., Bledow, R. and Stark, M.S. (2020), "A dynamic account of self-efficacy in entrepreneurship", *Journal of Applied Psychology*, Vol. 105 No. 5, pp. 487-505, doi: [10.1037/apl0000451](https://doi.org/10.1037/apl0000451).

- Gurău, C., Dana, L.-P. and Katz-Volovelsky, E. (2020), "Spanning transnational boundaries in industrial markets: a study of Israeli entrepreneurs in China", *Industrial Marketing Management*, Vol. 89, pp. 389-401, doi: [10.1016/j.indmarman.2020.01.008](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.indmarman.2020.01.008).
- Halbesleben, J.R.B. and Bowler, W.M. (2007), "Emotional exhaustion and job performance: the mediating role of motivation", *Journal of Applied Psychology*, Vol. 92 No. 1, pp. 93-106, doi: [10.1037/0021-9010.92.1.93](https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.92.1.93).
- Hobfoll, S.E., Freedy, J., Lane, C. and Geller, P. (1990), "Conservation of social resources: social support resource theory", *Journal of Social and Personal Relationships*, Vol. 7 No. 4, pp. 465-478, doi: [10.1177/0265407590074004](https://doi.org/10.1177/0265407590074004).
- Hobfoll, S.E., Halbesleben, J., Neveu, J.-P. and Westman, M. (2018), "Conservation of resources in the organizational context: the reality of resources and their consequences", *Annual Review of Organizational Psychology and Organizational Behavior*, Vol. 5 No. 1, pp. 103-128, doi: [10.1146/annurev-orgpsych-032117-104640](https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-orgpsych-032117-104640).
- Kim, S.L. and Yun, S. (2015), "The effect of coworker knowledge sharing on performance and its boundary conditions: an interactional perspective", *Journal of Applied Psychology*, Vol. 100 No. 2, pp. 575-582, doi: [10.1037/a0037834](https://doi.org/10.1037/a0037834).
- Kim, S.L., Lee, D. and Yun, S. (2022), "Leader boundary-spanning behavior and creative behavior: the role of need for status and creative self-efficacy", *The Leadership and Organization Development Journal*, Vol. 43 No. 6, pp. 835-846, doi: [10.1108/lodj-05-2021-0235](https://doi.org/10.1108/lodj-05-2021-0235).
- Lam, C.K., Huang, X. and Janssen, O. (2010), "Contextualizing emotional exhaustion and positive emotional display: the signaling effects of supervisors' emotional exhaustion and service climate", *Journal of Applied Psychology*, Vol. 95 No. 2, pp. 368-376, doi: [10.1037/a0017869](https://doi.org/10.1037/a0017869).
- Landers, R.N. and Behrend, T.S. (2015), "An inconvenient truth: arbitrary distinctions between organizational, Mechanical Turk, and other convenience samples", *Industrial and Organizational Psychology*, Vol. 8 No. 2, pp. 142-164, doi: [10.1017/iop.2015.13](https://doi.org/10.1017/iop.2015.13).
- Lavelle, J.J., Rupp, D.E., Herda, D.N., Pandey, A. and Lauck, J.R. (2021), "Customer injustice and employee performance: roles of emotional exhaustion, surface acting, and emotional demands-abilities fit", *Journal of Management*, Vol. 47 No. 3, pp. 654-682, doi: [10.1177/0149206319869426](https://doi.org/10.1177/0149206319869426).
- Leicht-Deobald, U., Lam, C.F., Bruch, H., Kunze, F. and Wu, W. (2022), "Team boundary work and team workload demands: their interactive effect on team vigor and team effectiveness", *Human Resource Management*, Vol. 61 No. 4, pp. 465-488, doi: [10.1002/hrm.22104](https://doi.org/10.1002/hrm.22104).
- Lian, H., Lance Ferris, D. and Brown, D.J. (2012), "Does taking the good with the bad make things worse? How abusive supervision and leader-member exchange interact to impact need satisfaction and organizational deviance", *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes*, Vol. 117 No. 1, pp. 41-52, doi: [10.1016/j.obhdp.2011.10.003](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.obhdp.2011.10.003).
- Liu, S., Jiang, K., Chen, J., Pan, J. and Lin, X. (2018), "Linking employee boundary spanning behavior to task performance: the influence of informal leader emergence and group power distance", *International Journal of Human Resource Management*, Vol. 29 No. 12, pp. 1879-1899, doi: [10.1080/09585192.2016.1216872](https://doi.org/10.1080/09585192.2016.1216872).
- Marrone, J.A. (2010), "Team boundary spanning: a multilevel review of past research and proposals for the future", *Journal of Management*, Vol. 36 No. 4, pp. 911-940, doi: [10.1177/0149206309353945](https://doi.org/10.1177/0149206309353945).
- Marrone, J.A., Quigley, N.R., Prussia, G.E. and Dienhart, J. (2022), "Can supportive coaching behaviors facilitate boundary spanning and raise job satisfaction? An indirect-effects model", *Journal of Management*, Vol. 48 No. 5, pp. 1131-1159, doi: [10.1177/01492063211003951](https://doi.org/10.1177/01492063211003951).
- Marrone, J.A., Tesluk, P.E. and Carson, J.B. (2007), "A multilevel investigation of antecedents and consequences of team member boundary-spanning behavior", *Academy of Management Journal*, Vol. 50 No. 6, pp. 1423-1439, doi: [10.5465/amj.2007.28225967](https://doi.org/10.5465/amj.2007.28225967).
- Maslach, C. and Jackson, S.E. (1981), "The measurement of experienced burnout", *Journal of Organizational Behavior*, Vol. 2 No. 2, pp. 99-113, doi: [10.1002/job.4030020205](https://doi.org/10.1002/job.4030020205).

- Maslach, C., Schaufeli, W.B. and Leiter, M.P. (2001), "Job burnout", *Annual Review of Psychology*, Vol. 52 No. 1, pp. 397-422, doi: [10.1146/annurev.psych.52.1.397](https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.psych.52.1.397).
- Muthén, B. and Muthén, L. (2017), *Mplus*, Chapman and Hall/CRC, Boca Raton, FL.
- Peng, A.C., Schaubroeck, J.M. and Li, Y. (2014), "Social exchange implications of own and CoWorkers' experiences of supervisory abuse", *Academy of Management Journal*, Vol. 57 No. 5, pp. 1385-1405, doi: [10.5465/amj.2012.0080](https://doi.org/10.5465/amj.2012.0080).
- Salem, M., Van Quaquebeke, N. and Besiou, M. (2018), "How field office leaders drive learning and creativity in humanitarian aid: exploring the role of boundary-spanning leadership for expatriate and local aid worker collaboration", *Journal of Organizational Behavior*, Vol. 39 No. 5, pp. 594-611, doi: [10.1002/job.2246](https://doi.org/10.1002/job.2246).
- Taylor, S.G. and Pattie, M.W. (2014), "When does ethical leadership affect workplace incivility? The moderating role of follower personality", *Business Ethics Quarterly*, Vol. 24 No. 4, pp. 595-616, doi: [10.5840/beq201492618](https://doi.org/10.5840/beq201492618).
- Tepper, B.J. (2000), "Consequences of abusive supervision", *Academy of Management Journal*, Vol. 43 No. 2, pp. 178-190, doi: [10.5465/1556375](https://doi.org/10.5465/1556375).
- Venkataramani, V., Richter, A.W. and Clarke, R. (2014), "Creative benefits from well-connected leaders: leader social network ties as facilitators of employee radical creativity", *Journal of Applied Psychology*, Vol. 99 No. 5, pp. 966-975, doi: [10.1037/a0037088](https://doi.org/10.1037/a0037088).
- Vullingsh, J.T., De Hoogh, A.H.B., Den Hartog, D.N. and Boon, C. (2020), "Ethical and passive leadership and their joint relationships with burnout via role clarity and role overload", *Journal of Business Ethics*, Vol. 165 No. 4, pp. 719-733, doi: [10.1007/s10551-018-4084-y](https://doi.org/10.1007/s10551-018-4084-y).
- Williams, L.J. and Anderson, S.E. (1991), "Job satisfaction and organizational commitment as predictors of organizational citizenship and in-role behaviors", *Journal of Management*, Vol. 17 No. 3, pp. 601-617, doi: [10.1177/014920639101700305](https://doi.org/10.1177/014920639101700305).
- Xu, Z., Gao, F., Fa, A., Qu, W. and Zhang, Z. (2024), "Statistical power analysis and sample size planning for moderated mediation models", *Behavior Research Methods*, Vol. 56 No. 6, pp. 6130-6149, doi: [10.3758/s13428-024-02342-2](https://doi.org/10.3758/s13428-024-02342-2).
- Zhang, Q. and Li, J. (2021), "Can employee's boundary-spanning behavior exactly promote innovation performance? The roles of creative ideas generation and team task interdependence", *International Journal of Manpower*, Vol. 42 No. 6, pp. 1047-1063, doi: [10.1108/IJM-06-2019-0302](https://doi.org/10.1108/IJM-06-2019-0302).

Corresponding author

Sunghyuck Mah can be contacted at: ryanshmah@gmail.com